

men, a conglomeration of the unruly no one wanted to coach.

After all, Graham Ford had taken one look at India and fled and in place the Indians sent out a 73-year-old manager. Fortress England was looking strong, so what if these gifted barbarians were at the gate? In the time it took for Harry Potter to arrive and vanquish Lord Voldemort forever, India have wiped a slateful of bad memories clean. When the grumbling about the 1-0 scoreline dies down, the team's

achievement will resonate. In the space of two months, India have defeated the world's No. 2 odi team, South Africa and the world's No. 2 Test team, England. It has been unexpected and it has been exceptional in its execution. The Indians even hexed the annoying jinx of winning a Test and then losing the next. In what seems like an omen, the team couldn't consume all the bottles of champagne ordered after the Trent Bridge victory. They carried the rest to the Oval and finished the lot

when the job was finally done.

As he sat contemplating his first home series defeat as captain, Michael Vaughan confessed that had he been offered a scenario where none of the frontline Indian batsmen would get a Test century in England he said, "I would have ripped your hand off." The statistics from the series are unusual: the same eleven played in all three Tests, the runs came in an even spread from the main batsmen, barring captain Rahul Dravid. He was however, delighted, "That's what Indian cricket needs—different heroes."

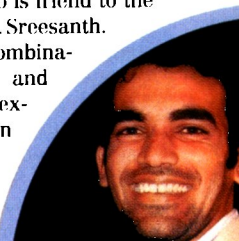
In the Tests, the Indians found a fair sprinkling, among them opener Dinesh Karthik and renaissance man Sourav Ganguly, batting with the authority of a man who knew his own destiny. Karthik, who made his debut as an 18-year-old wicketkeeper in 2004, now averages 53.3 as an opener. He is hyperactive and keen, a man who can bridge situations and people, an "Art of Living" devotee who is friend to the incomprehensible S. Sreesanth.

The new opening combination of Karthik and Wasim Jaffer was expected to be tested in England, but has blunted the new ball in hostile conditions. In a series of very tight margins, it was the contributions from the Indian tail (see box) that tilted the balance: per man per Test, England's top six averaged more than the Indians. But the Indian bottom five, led by M.S. Dhoni who held on to save the Lord's Test and made 209 runs in the series, scored more than double the runs than the English tail.

England's best bowler James Anderson admitted, "You can't say that it's been easy batting in this series but India's batsmen have scored steadily, coped well and kept going while conditions have chopped and changed." Dravid was at pains to point that they may have had no head coach, but the division of duties was clear. Bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad, fielding coach



against England and the collective joy heralds a new confidence and team spirit



"You thought I was bowling JELLY BEANS?"

ZAHEER KHAN to ALASTAIR COOK during the second Test at Nottingham.